1 #1 Lead Author: Christian Margo Hansen, Calling Bullshit on: *"Fox News Poll: State of the Union is dysfunction, dissatisfaction and disapproval"*

The article generally focuses on how dissatisfied Americans are with the current state of their country and leadership, using polling data to back up their claims. 81% of those interviewed consider America to be a "dysfunctional family", with only 45% expressing a "great deal/some" confidence in Biden's as president.

Given that the article was published shortly before President Biden's State of the Union speech, and the animosity Fox News has towards Biden[1], it appears that this survey and article were produced to serve as confirmation bias that the current administration and President Biden are doing a poor job.

Only allowing interviewees the options of choosing between the US being "tight-knit" or "dysfunctional" is very leading, especially with increasing partisan polarization[2]. It is unsurprising that the majority view the US as the latter. This is also the only statistic in the article that groups Republicans and Independents against Democrats. While it may be of little significance, it is somewhat suspicious.

The article also provides no information on the demographic breakdown of interviewees. Biden's approval is reported to be 45% overall, while at 88% amongst Democrats. This essentially indicates that all Republicans interviewed disapprove of Biden, which is not very surprising given the hyper-partisan state of the US. However, there are other factors which could influence this choice, other than party affiliation, all which are completely ignored in this survey.

These types of leading questions, and the bluntness with which the data is presented, can potentially cause people to have a bleak overview of the current state of the country, and act as confirmation bias for any that have doubts towards the current administration. Asking questions and presenting information in a polarized manner, without allowing for anything in between, also risks fueling harsh political divides.

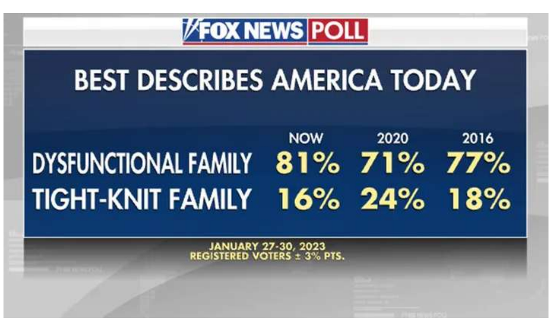

Figure 1: How poll takers describe the US

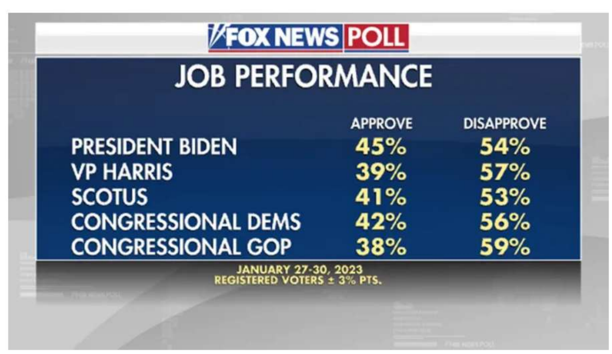

Figure 2: Views on the job performance of various politicians

2 #2 Lead Author: Christian Margo Hansen, Calling Bullshit on: *"Vehicles That Are Involved in the Most Fatal Accidents in the U.S."*

This article, and investigation, by the TitleMax team claims that the “Chevrolet Silverado is the vehicle most likely to get into an accident”; based on vehicle fatality data from 2016-2020.

The article is accompanied by a prominent visualisation, which clearly highlights the Silverado as being more dangerous to drive than any other vehicle. The visualisation and data are not normalized with regards to how many of each type of vehicle is driven in the United States, which is an example of unfair comparison. The author also states that one is “[more] likely to get into [a fatal] accident” if they are driving a Silverado, making only brief mention that “the Silverado is also the second most-popular car in America”. If there are significantly more Silverado’s on the road compared to the majority of other vehicle types, it is of course more likely that fatal crashes will involve that specific model. This bold claim serves as an example of the prosecutor’s fallacy, in that:

$$P(\text{Being in a Fatal Accident}|\text{Driving a Silverado}) \neq P(\text{Driving a Silverado}|\text{Being in a Fatal Accident})$$

Using the number of each type of car sold[3] as a proxy for the number of each type of car being driven, the most dangerous car to drive between 2016-2020 was the Chevrolet Impala; which was present in 972 fatal accidents per 100.000 units sold. The supposedly deadly Silverado saw 300 fatal accidents per 100.000 units sold[1].

In this specific case, this type of misleading information mostly has the potential to be damaging to a car manufacturer’s brand.

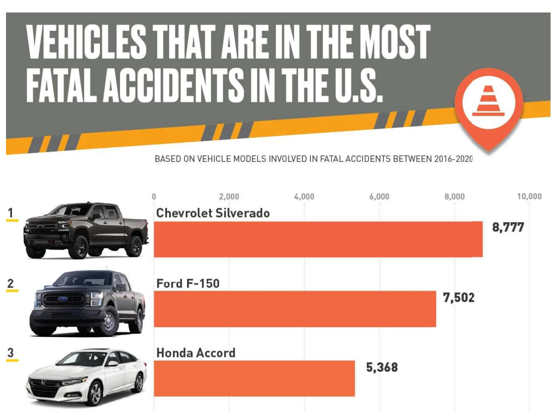

Figure 3: Top 3 of the 25 deadliest vehicles in the US according to TitleMax

[1] It must be stated, that the figures for vehicles sold may not be entirely accurate either, but this attempt to normalise the data serves mainly to highlight the questionable claims of the article and visualisation.